

Damian Barabonkov

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WORK EXPERIENCE — US Citizen and EU Citizen

ellamind GmbH

Jul. 2024 – Present

Founding AI Engineer (2nd employee)

Berlin, DE

- Shipped Full LLM Evaluation SaaS Platform (0 → 1)
 - **Delivered a production-ready system in 9 months**, matching the output of 10+ engineer teams by leveraging deep engineering expertise and AI tooling
 - **Architected scalable backend** (Postgres, Django REST API, Python SDK, Next.js Frontend) with CI/CD and containerized environments (Docker, GitHub Actions) for dev, testing and production
 - **Authored design specifications** and circulated them with stakeholders; finalized specs doubled as structured prompts for AI coding tools (**Claude Code, Codex**), accelerating feature development
- Architected Platform Centered around LLM Evaluation Workflows and Best Practices
 - **Reproduced industry-standard benchmarks** (GPQA, MMLU) to evaluate new model releases
 - **Designed custom evaluation suites** for niche memorization tasks, non-English performance, geographic reasoning, and multi-turn agents in sandboxed environments with side effects
 - Integrated insights from running evaluations to optimize and improve the platform user experience
- Customer-First and Leverage-Oriented Decision Making
 - **Delivered actionable evaluation dashboards** enabling detailed analysis of cross-model, prompt, and agent comparisons; accelerated product adoption through customer interviews and tight feedback loops.
 - **Reduced time-to-ship** by scoping features that maximized customer value with minimal complexity
- Led Recruiting Initiatives to Scale Headcount from **4 to 10 employees**
 - Designed technical screening and onsite coding challenges to assess engineering talent and passion
 - **Conducted 50+ technical interviews** and all onsite coding sessions

QuantCo Inc.

Oct. 2021 – Jan. 2024

Machine Learning & Software Engineer

Berlin, DE

- Led development of client-facing machine learning dashboard with on-call duties
 - **Modernized backend** to include incremental backups, unit & integration tests, continuous deployment
- Created *groupstorm* library, a hyper-fast and flexible DataFrame group by implementation
 - Reduced runtime latency from 30 minutes to under a minute
 - **Utilized performance engineering techniques**: sparse-matrices, categorical comparisons, lazy evaluation, data sharding, shared memory, line profiling, cachegrind profiling
- Extended internal feature engineering framework used by **3 separate projects** across **2 clients**
 - Scoped and implemented incremental feature recomputations, yielding **10x** overall performance boost
 - Identified bugs and contributed patches to popular Python packages: **pandas, numpy, eigen**

Facebook Inc.

June 2018 – Aug. 2018

Performance and Capacity Engineer Intern

Menlo Park, CA

- Expanded upon existing profiler to collect additional database performance metrics across Facebook's services
 - Tuned database utilization of production services to improve performance with large cost-saving results

EDUCATION

Massachusetts Institute of Technology — 5.0/5.0 GPA

May, 2021

MEng, Computer Science

Cambridge, MA

- Masters Thesis: [Guarda](#) — A web application firewall for WebAuthn transaction authentication

Massachusetts Institute of Technology — 4.9/5.0 GPA

May, 2020

BSc, Computer Science and Engineering

Cambridge, MA

SOFTWARE SKILLS

- **Programming**: Python, C, C++, Go, OCaml, Haskell
- **Frameworks and Tools**: Linux, Django, Next.js, Docker, GitHub Actions, Postgres
- **AI Tools**: Claude Code with Sub-agents, OpenAI Codex, Aider